> independent fellows assume generally when sitting in a chair leaning forward dogmatically and brow-beating the rest of the company, such as I have seen [Charles James] Fox assume in the House of Commons when preparing to rise and thunder his invective against corrupt ministers. The spot we stood upon is the same which his subjects first humble themselves in the presence; where his public demands are executed and where justice receives his sanction; but where perhaps tyranny obtains more speedy obedience . . . My eyes rested at the ground by my feet: it was stained with blood.

When the Shah came down from the throne to move to the hall of audience, Fraser judged him to be about five feet six inches tall, and described his colour as ‘very fair, but dead, without any ruddiness. His beard was thick jet black and shortened a little by the scissors. His eyebrows were high but unarched, and had a slope obliquely upwards, but turned again a little at the corners . . . The eyelashes and the edges of his eyelids were blackened with antimony, and his eyebrows and beard were also blackened by art.’ His voice, he added, was ‘loud and sonorous’.

> His dress was superb, the crown very peculiar and ornamented with jewels. I believe it was hexagonal, and at each corner rose a rich plume of black heron’s feather . . . a badge of sovereignty and a mark of God’s chosen upon earth. The frame of the crown must have been of black velvet, but the feathers and gold so completely covered the ground that I could not accurately discover every precious stone that had a place, but emeralds, rubies and pearls were the most prevalent, and of extraordinary size and beauty.[39]

Negotiations between Shuja and the British about their alliance continued for several weeks.

Shuja was keen for an alliance with the Company, and was especially anxious for British assistance in protecting his lands which had been promised by Napoleon to the Persians. But he was distracted by the bad news arriving in Peshawar from all sides. For all the magnificence of his court, the Shah’s hold on the throne was far more tenuous than the British had realised. As Elphinstone and Fraser both soon came to suspect, Shah Shuja’s obsession with the theatre of his court was to some extent a front to disguise the extreme weakness of his position.

Shuja’s problems stemmed partly from his own declared intention to bring a new dignity to Afghan politics. In 1803, when he had first come to power and released Shah Zaman from imprisonment, he had disdained to exercise the customary punishment of blinding his defeated half-brother, Shah Mahmoud. ‘We find greater sweetness in forgiveness than in revenge,’